

INTELLUM

THE 2026 STATE OF

Education-Led Growth Report

How Companies Turn Education Into a Strategic Growth Engine

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Education has become a strategic lever for how organizations grow, adapt, and perform. Today, the most effective programs are aligned to clear business outcomes. As education teams use AI to scale content, personalize learning, and coach more efficiently, education is becoming more deeply embedded across the business. The organizations that combine strong measurement, thoughtful use of AI, and a focus on enabling every audience will be the ones that lead.



Chip Ramsey
CEO of Intellum

Executive Summary



Education is expanding beyond retention into revenue growth.

While implementation, product adoption, and retention remain the most common lifecycle stages for education programs, focus on customer expansion has increased significantly year over year. This shift reflects how organizations are beginning to view education not only as a support or retention tool, but as a strategic lever for driving expansion revenue and long-term customer value.



Executive representation is increasing—and it matters.

Education leadership is gradually moving higher within organizations. More programs now report executive-level oversight, while fewer report leadership limited to manager-level roles. Programs led by C-level or VP leaders demonstrate stronger indicators of maturity, including higher learner completion rates, broader use of analytics tools, and greater investment in emerging technologies such as AI.



AI adoption has moved from experimentation to everyday implementation.

AI is now widely used across education programs, with the vast majority of organizations reporting active use. Teams are prioritizing AI for accelerating written content creation, supporting learners through automation, and assisting with strategic planning. As adoption becomes universal, the focus is shifting from whether to use AI to how organizations can use it effectively to scale content, personalize learning, and improve operational efficiency.



Marketing and analytics capabilities are becoming key enablers of education impact.

Programs with stronger marketing support and analytics capabilities are better positioned to drive measurable business outcomes. External-facing education programs benefit from greater marketing investment, while internal programs often operate with fewer promotional resources. At the same time, education data increasingly connects with systems like CRM and support platforms, expanding the analytics ecosystem around the LMS.



Measurement maturity is improving across education teams.

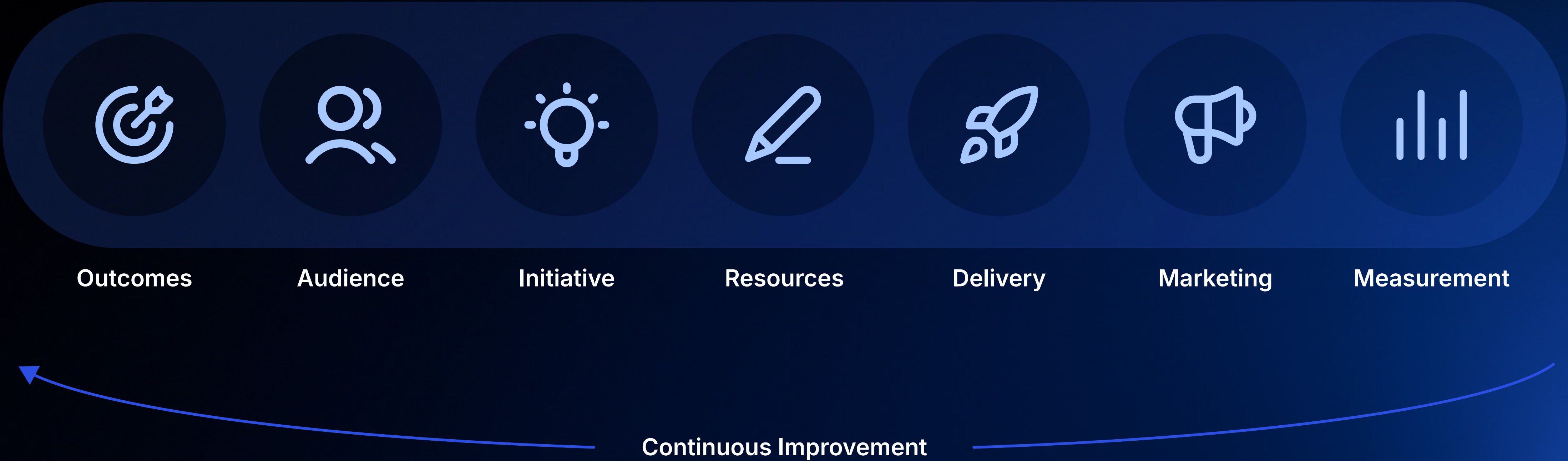
Organizations are demonstrating stronger discipline around measuring education impact. A growing share of teams now begin measuring outcomes within the first three months of launching a new initiative, and far fewer programs report inconsistent measurement practices compared with the previous year. Teams that measure earlier are also more likely to adopt specialized analytics tools, indicating a stronger focus on proving education’s business value.



What is Education-Led Growth?

Education-Led Growth (ELG) is a strategic framework positioning employee, customer, and partner education as a primary driver of business growth. By aligning education with revenue, retention, and adoption goals, companies can create measurable business impact.

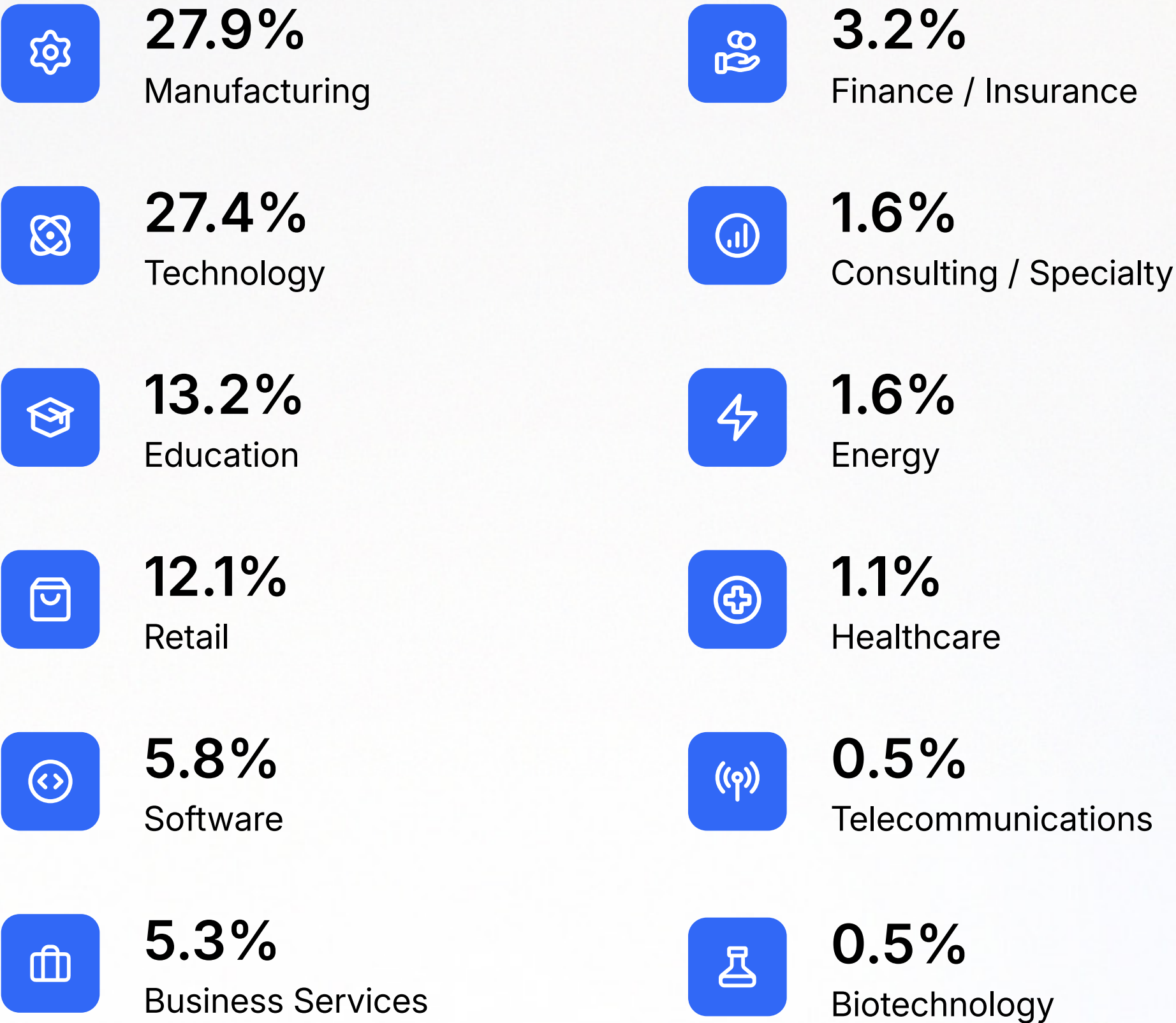
Education-Led Growth™ Framework



Industry

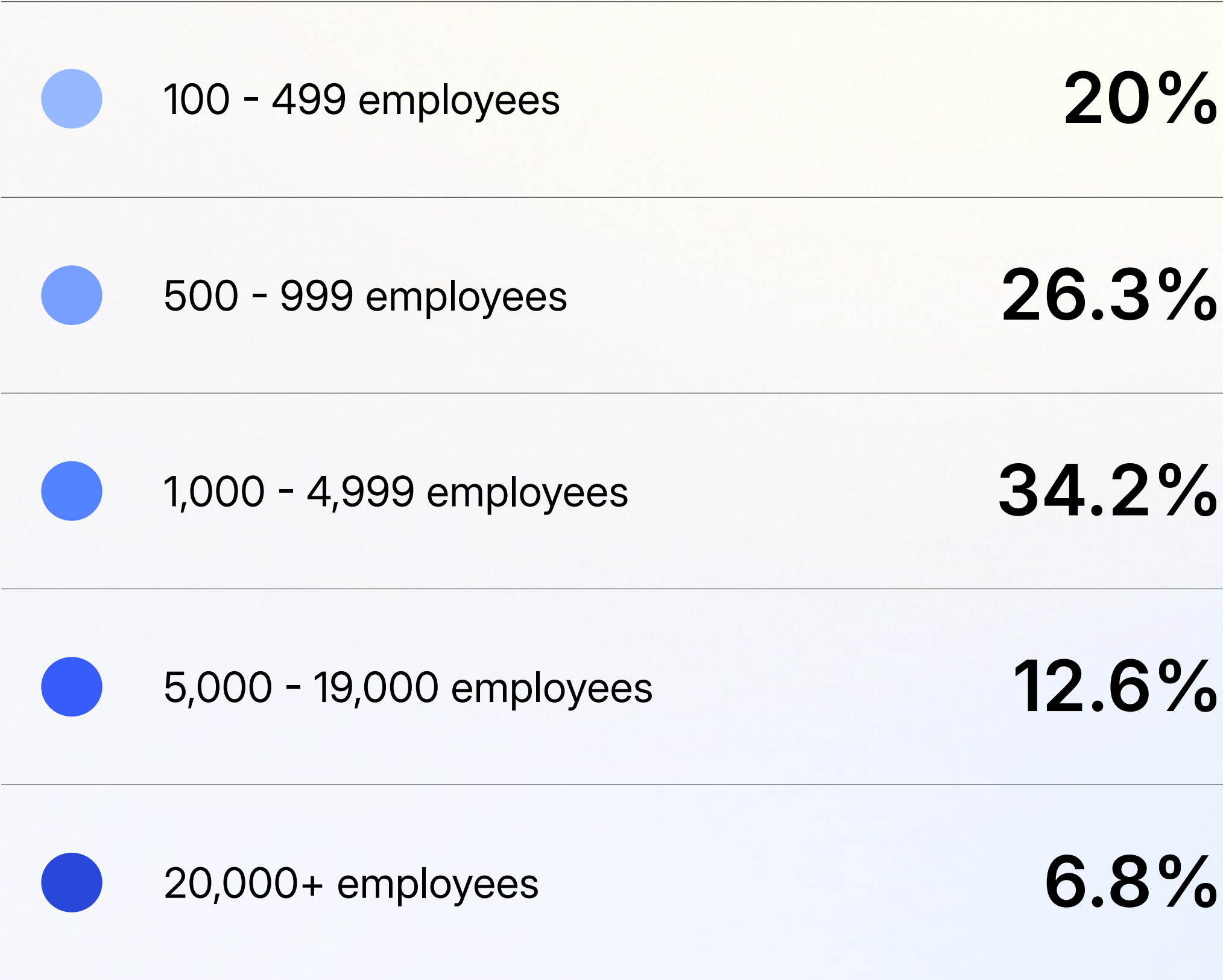
Most respondents work in the manufacturing or technology industry (55.3%), with the remaining 44.7% representing other industries.

Respondents were primarily U.S.-based.



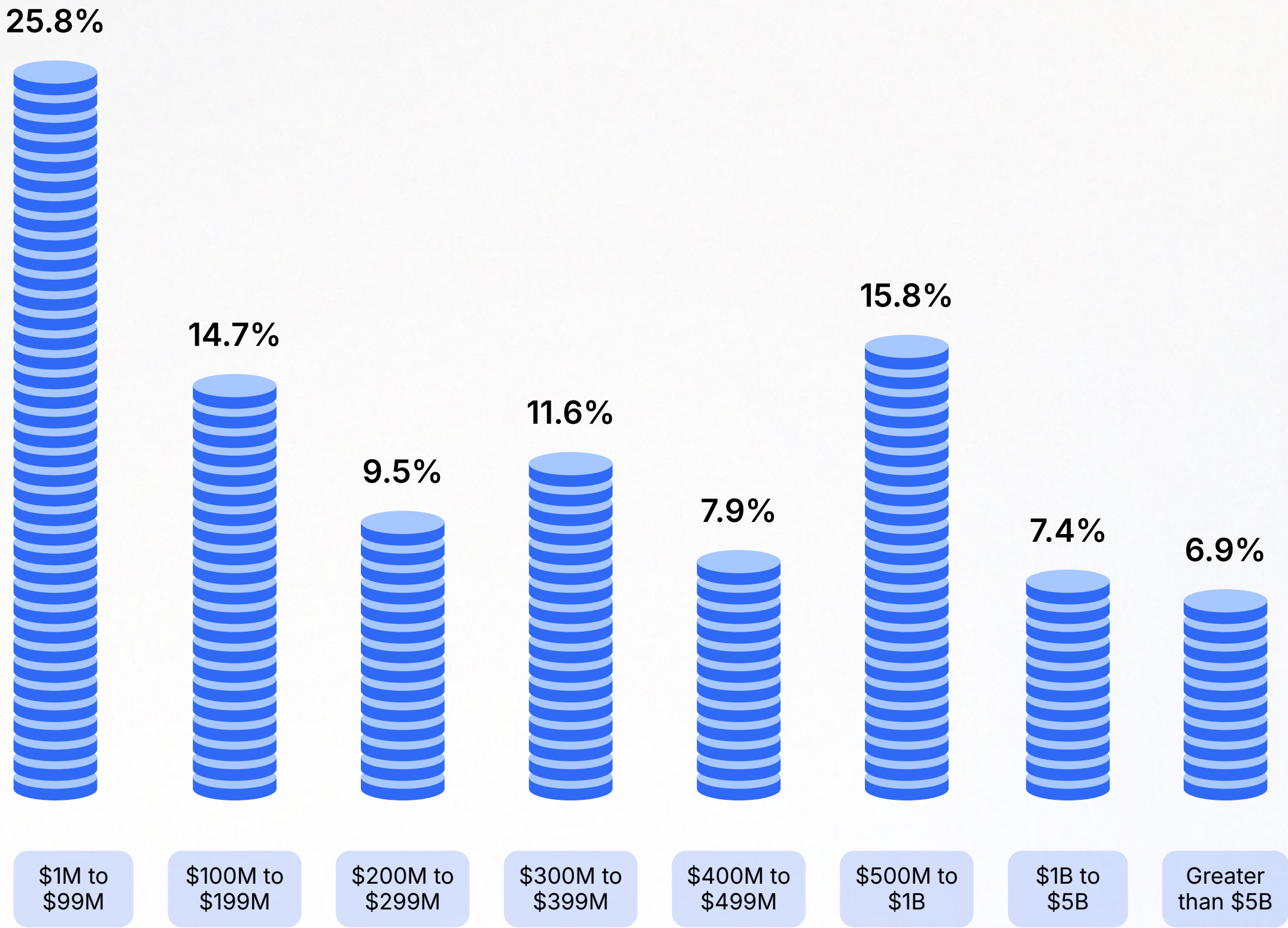
Company Size

The respondents represented companies with a wide range of employee headcount, largely focusing on enterprise.

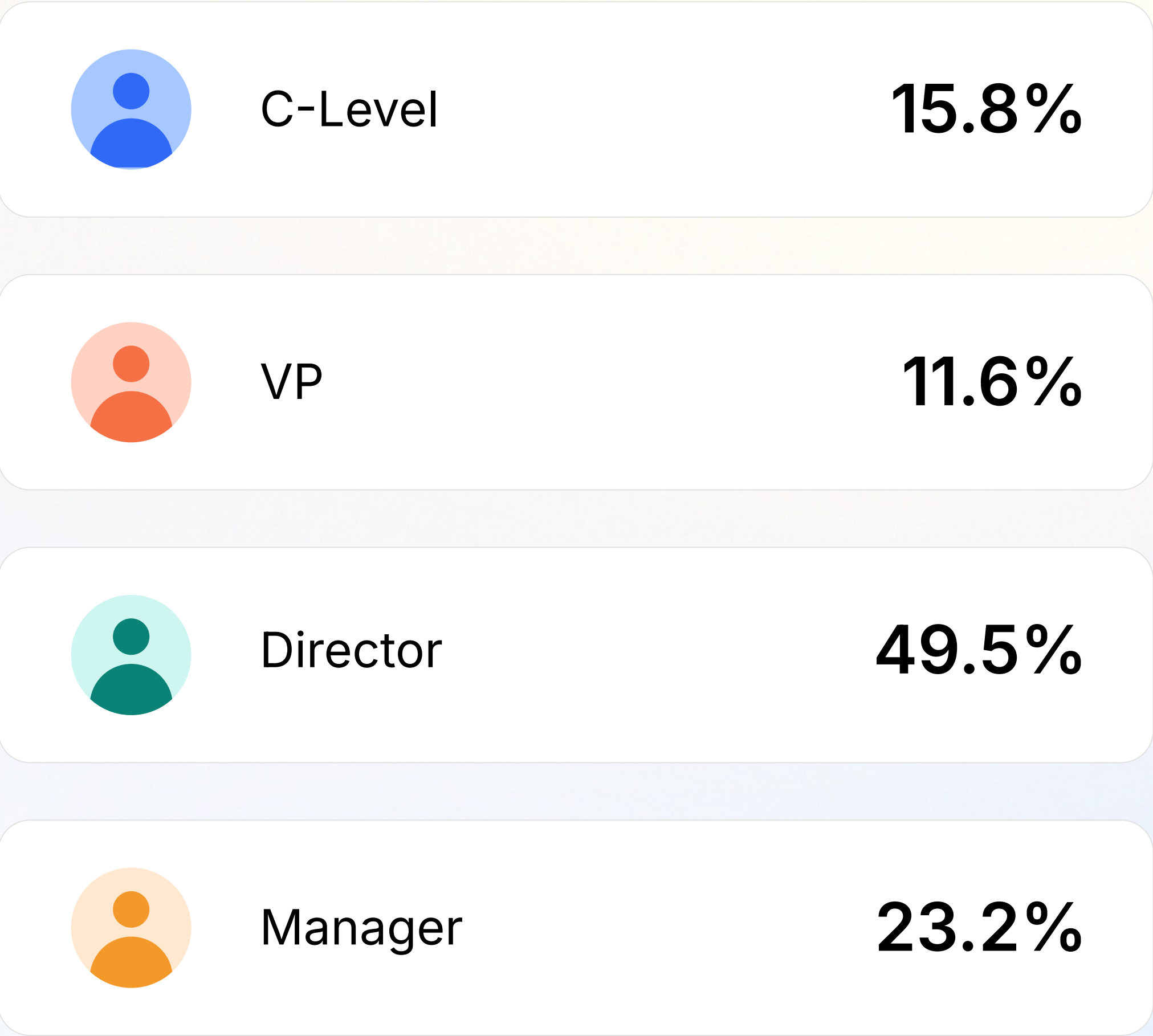


Company Revenue

Nearly three-quarters (74.2%) of surveyed organizations reported annual revenue exceeding \$100M.



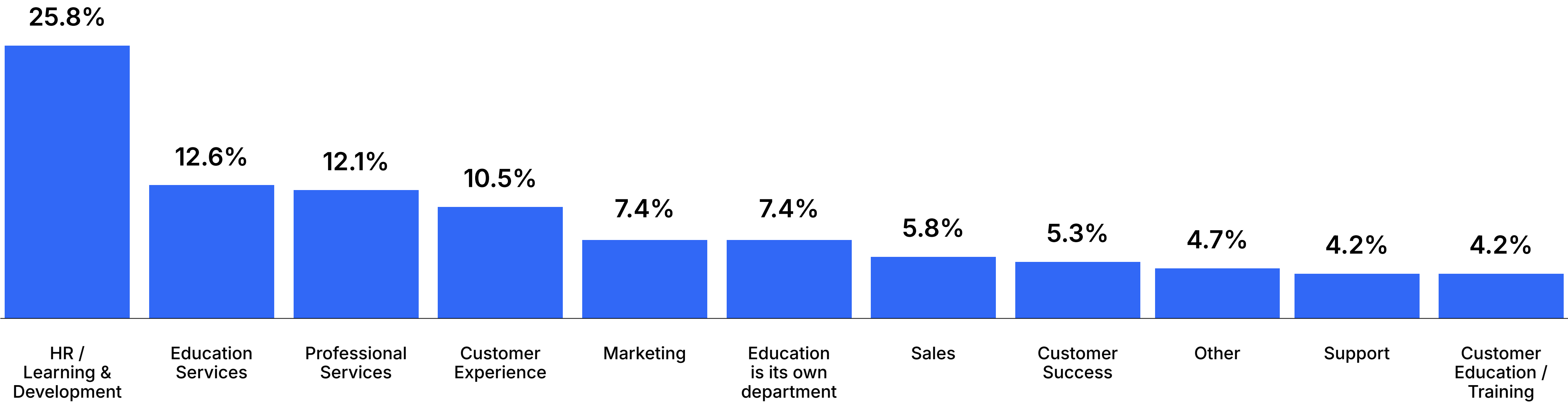
Roles Represented



Education teams are embedded across the business.

The majority of respondents reported into HR/Learning & Development (25.8%), Education Services (12.6%), or Professional Services (12.1%), with representation in other functions across the organization.

Q: Which of the following best describes the department your education team reports to? (Select one.)



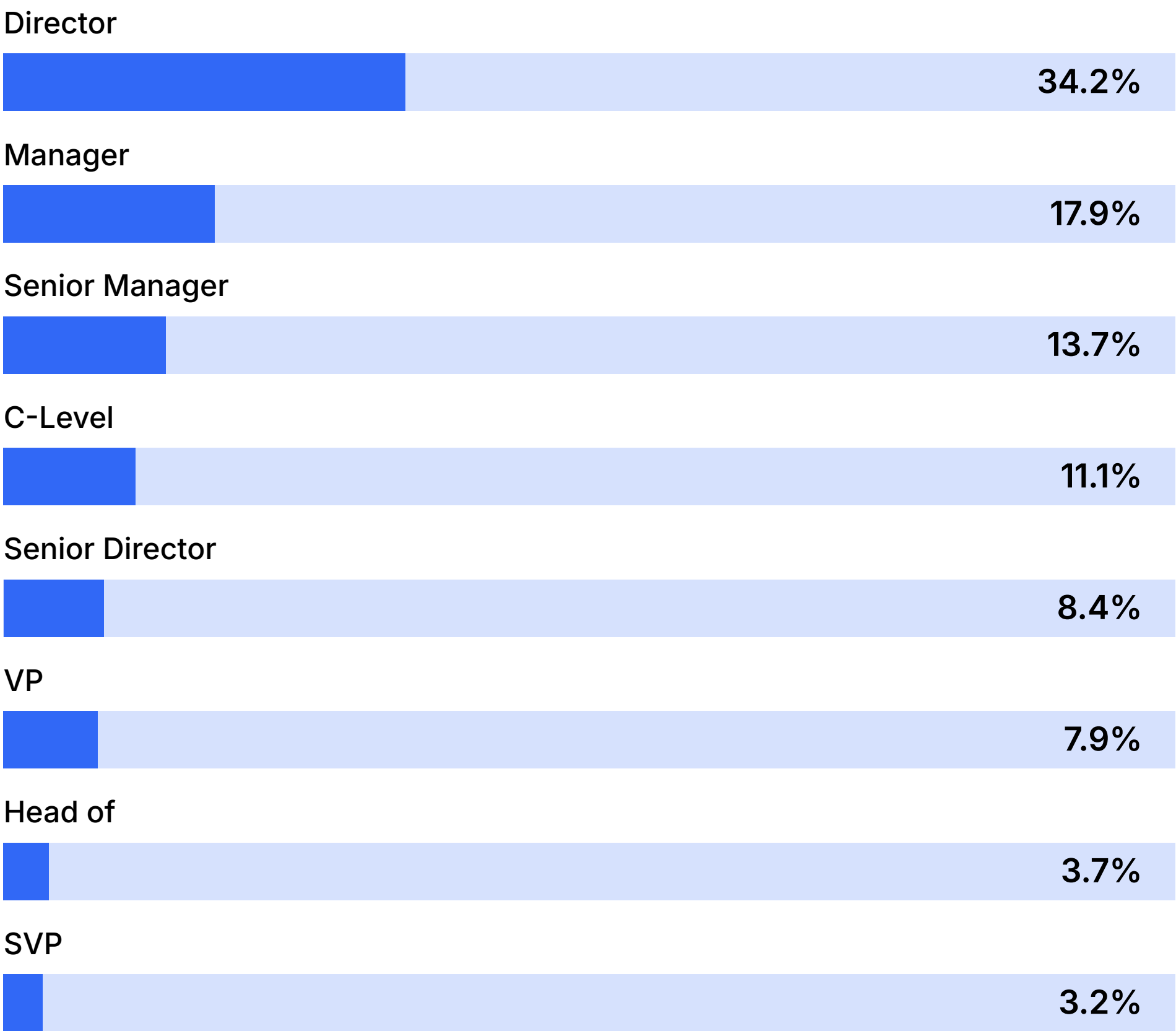
Senior-level representation matters.

Education leadership is gradually moving higher in the organization. In 2026, 22.2% of respondents report executive-level leadership for their education programs, an increase from 2025. At the same time, 31.6% report their highest level of leadership as manager or senior manager, indicating that many programs are still building senior representation.

Programs with C-level or VP leadership show stronger indicators of maturity. These teams report higher learner completion rates and greater use of data visualization tools, suggesting a stronger focus on measurement and demonstrating business impact.

Executive leaders also show a strong commitment to emerging technologies, particularly AI. Compared with other leadership levels, C-level and VP leaders more frequently prioritize AI for content creation, strategic planning, and predictive insights, reinforcing the role executive representation plays in shaping education as a strategic growth function.

Q: What is the highest title for your customer/partner education program?



Customer support, customer success, and product teams are the top collaboration partners.

Nearly 59% of respondents collaborate closely with Customer Support and Customer Success teams, reinforcing education’s role in supporting customer outcomes and retention. Product (55%) and Sales (55%) are also key collaborators, highlighting education’s growing alignment with product adoption and revenue enablement. Marketing teams partner with nearly half of education programs (48%), while collaboration with Customer Experience remains less common (24%), suggesting an opportunity to better connect education with broader customer journey initiatives.

Q: Which other teams do you collaborate with most closely?
(Select all that apply.)



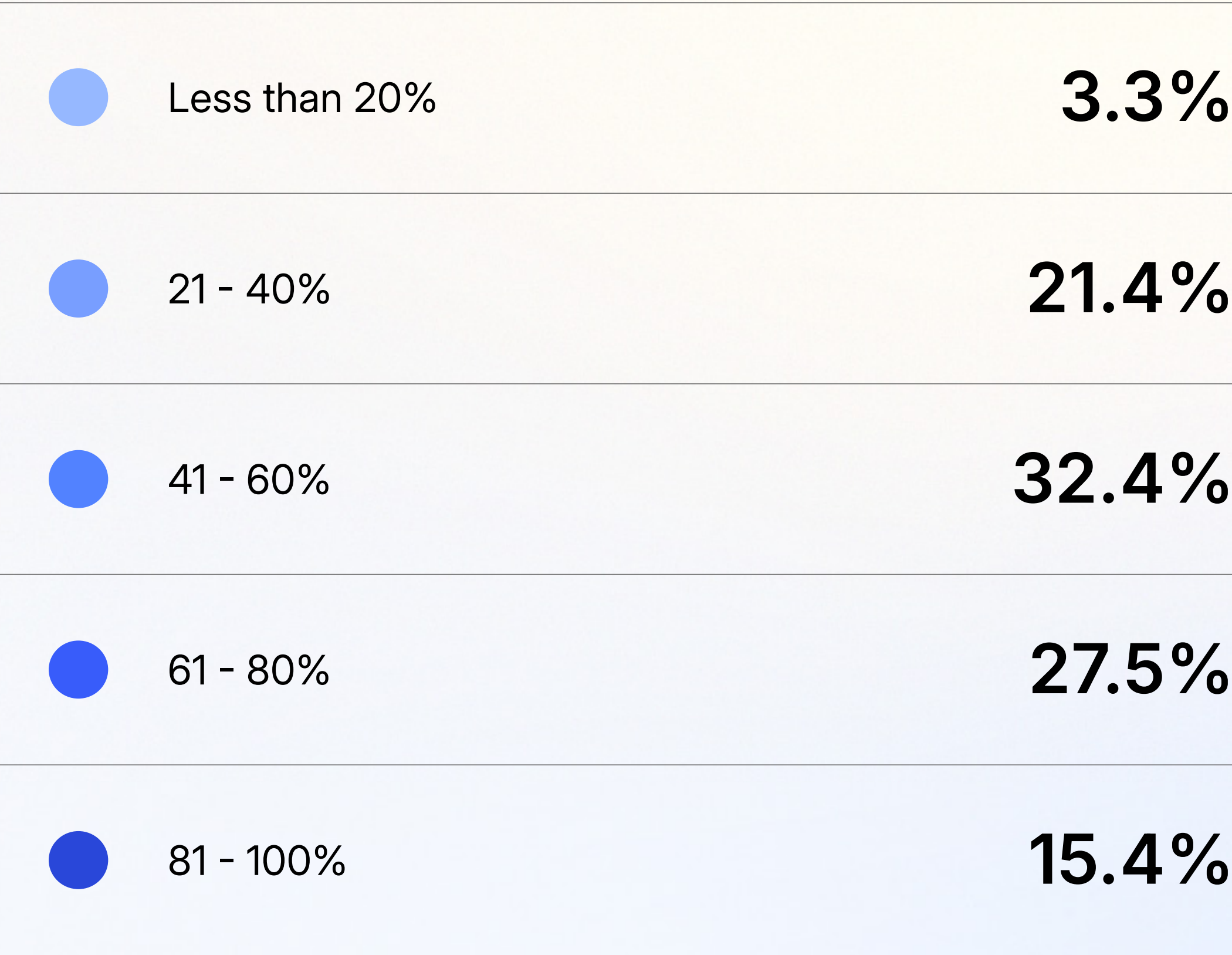
Education programs reach a meaningful share of their audience, but rarely the entire base.

Training participation varies significantly depending on the audience being educated. Internal audiences—particularly employee L&D programs—report the highest completion rates, with the largest share of respondents indicating annual completion rates of over 80%.

By contrast, external audiences such as prospects and partners report much lower participation levels. Among respondents educating prospects, 42.1% report completion rates below 20%, while 36.5% of partner education programs fall into the same lowest tier.

While reaching 100% of any audience is unrealistic, these findings highlight a clear gap between internal training adoption and external education engagement, suggesting opportunities to expand the reach and effectiveness of programs aimed at customers, partners, and prospective users.

Q: What percentage of your educated audience completes at least one educational program or training per year?



The majority of education programs are offered for free—charging mainly for live training.

Of those surveyed who educate external audiences, less than a quarter did not charge for any of their education programs. For those who did charge, 13.9% charged only for live training, 6% for on-demand only, and 53.6% for both on-demand and live training.

While charging for education creates opportunities for revenue, the decision to charge varies based on goals.

Q: Do you charge for your education programs? (Choose the option most relevant to you.)



53.6%

YES:
Both on-demand + live



26.5%

NO



13.9%

YES:
Only live training



6%

YES:
Only on-demand training

Business Outcomes

Within the Education-Led Growth framework, we focus on four core business outcomes—**revenue**, **retention**, **performance**, and **cost reduction**—that define the strategic impact of education programs.



Revenue



Retention



Performance



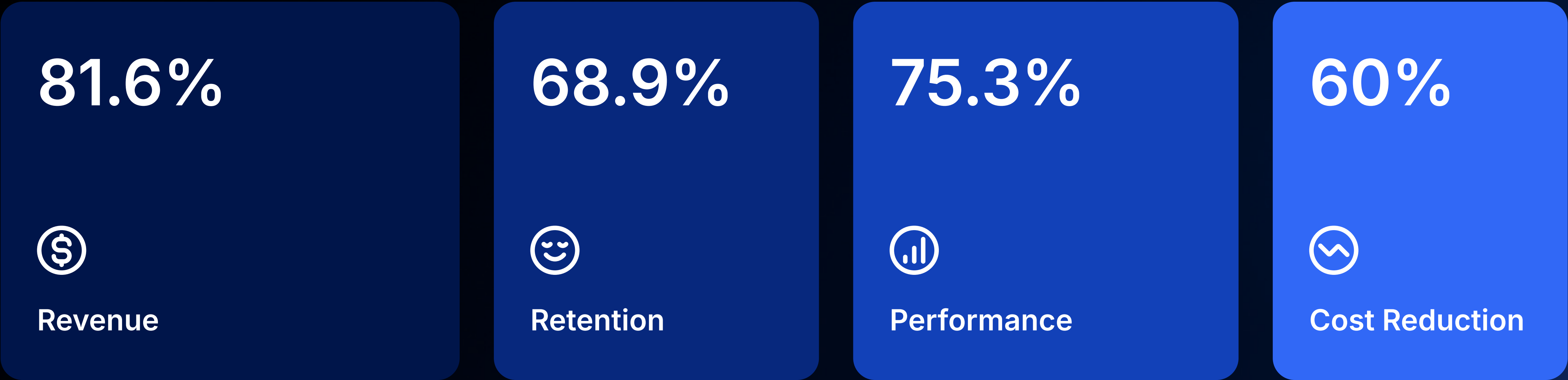
Cost Reduction

Revenue and performance metrics take priority.

Similar to 2025, cost reduction (60%) remains the least prioritized objective, indicating that most organizations are positioning education as a growth driver rather than purely an operational efficiency tool.

In these numbers:

- **Revenue** includes increased revenue, increased product activation, and increased active users.
- **Retention** includes reduced churn, improved sentiment, and improved product adoption.
- **Performance** includes improved ramp time, increased goal attainment, and enhanced skill proficiency.
- **Cost Reduction** includes reduced content creation, support, and onboarding costs.





Education priorities shift toward revenue and efficiency as teams scale.

Education team size continues to shape strategic priorities, though the pattern shifted from 2025. Larger teams (51–99 and 100+ employees) are now most likely to prioritize revenue growth (~55%), while also showing the strongest focus on cost reduction—especially the 51–99 group (69%). Smaller teams, particularly 5–10 employees, also track revenue and cost closely, reflecting a strong emphasis on demonstrating clear financial impact.

Audience

This research represents a holistic look at education—employees, customers, partners, and prospects.

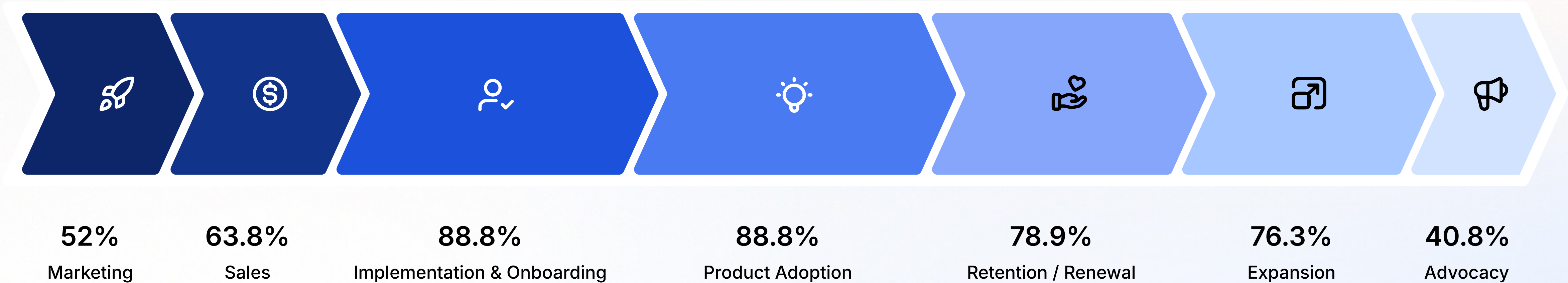
Q: Which of the following audiences do you educate? (Select all that apply.)
*Employees includes L&D, product enablement, and sales enablement.



Education is growing across the customer lifecycle.

For programs educating external audiences, the top most common lifecycle stages education is applied to are still implementation (88%), product adoption (88%), and retention/renewal (78.9%). Focus on expansion has climbed 20 percentage points year over year, highlighting the potential for education to impact customer growth revenue.

Q: Which stages of the customer lifecycle do your education programs target? (Select all that apply.)

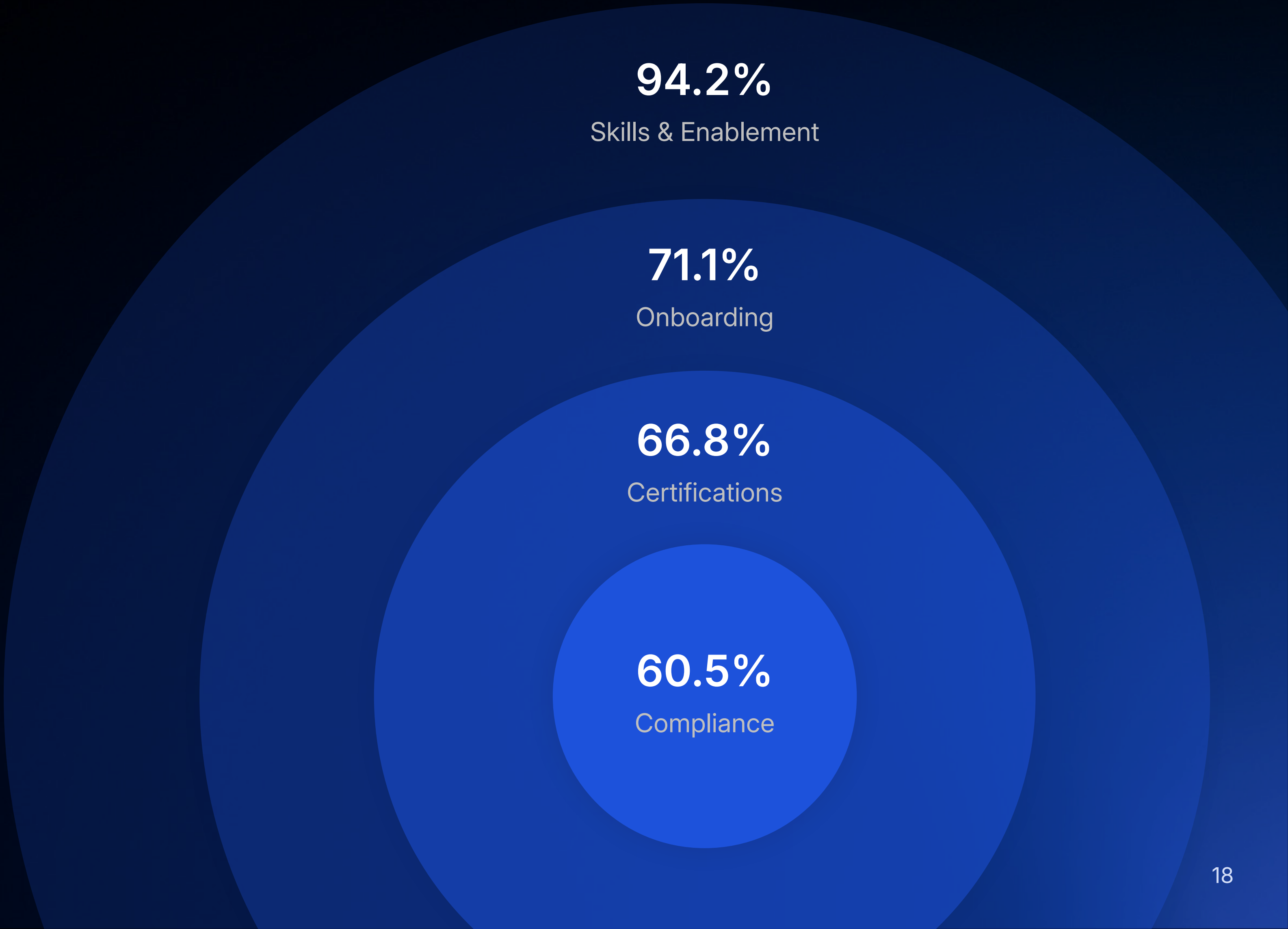


Top Education Initiatives

Skills and enablement remain the primary focus for education teams in 2026. More than 94% of respondents report skills & enablement initiatives, making it the most common education use case by a wide margin.

Overall, the distribution of initiatives remains largely consistent with 2025, with skills and enablement continuing to serve as the foundation of most education programs.

Q: Which of the following education initiatives is your team responsible for? (Select all that apply.)





Certifications and compliance initiatives scale with company size and industry demands.

While skills & enablement and onboarding remain common across all organizations, larger companies are significantly more likely to offer formal certification and compliance initiatives. Compliance reaches its highest levels among organizations with 20,000+ employees, while certification programs are most common in companies with 5,000–19,999 employees. This reflects the greater regulatory complexity and program maturity typical of large-scale education organizations.

Industry also plays a role: highly regulated sectors such as Finance and Insurance report the highest use of compliance initiatives, while Education, Software, and Technology lead in certification programs.

Structured and video-based learning dominate education programs.

Training videos remain the most widely used content type (68.4%), followed by virtual and in-person instructor-led training, reinforcing the continued importance of structured, instructor-supported learning. Knowledge base content and certification programs also remain common. Compared to [2024 Forrester Research](#), where in-app guides ranked highest, in-app messaging now trails significantly (34.2%), suggesting a return to more formalized and scalable learning experiences rather than leaning heavily on embedded, just-in-time guidance.

Q: Which of the following education or training methods does your company use? (Select all that apply.)

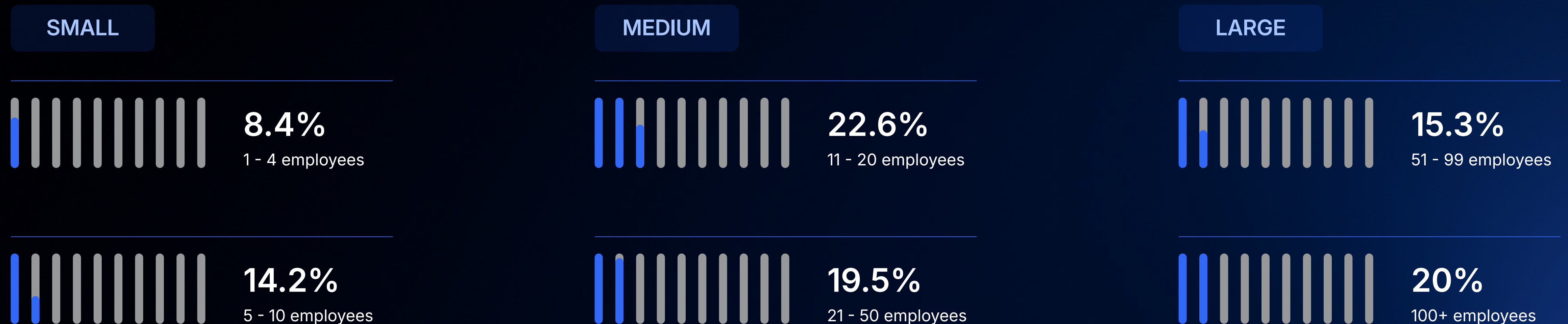
1. Training videos (e.g., how-tos)	68.4%	7. Customer community	42.1%
2. Virtual instructor-led training	59.5%	8. Published training documentation	41.6%
3. Instructor-led training (in-person)	57.4%	9. Prebuilt courseware or product/service training modules	41.6%
4. Knowledge base/help articles	55.8%	10. Custom eLearning	41.6%
5. Certification program	55.8%	11. In-app guides	34.2%
6. On-demand, long-form videos	48.4%		

Education team size varies based on company headcount.

Education team size varies widely across organizations. The largest share of respondents (22.6%) report teams of 11–20 employees, followed by 100+ employees (20%) and 21–50 employees (19.5%). This indicates a broad mix of mid-sized and large education functions.

The data suggests that education team size is strongly correlated with the company's overall size.

Q: Using your best estimate, how many employees are on your education team? (Select one.)



External vendors play a key role in resource strategy.

Just over 83.1% of respondents shared they use external vendors to support their education programs. Vendors are leveraged across company and education team sizes.

Q: Does your organization use outside vendors/partners to support your education initiatives?

83.1%

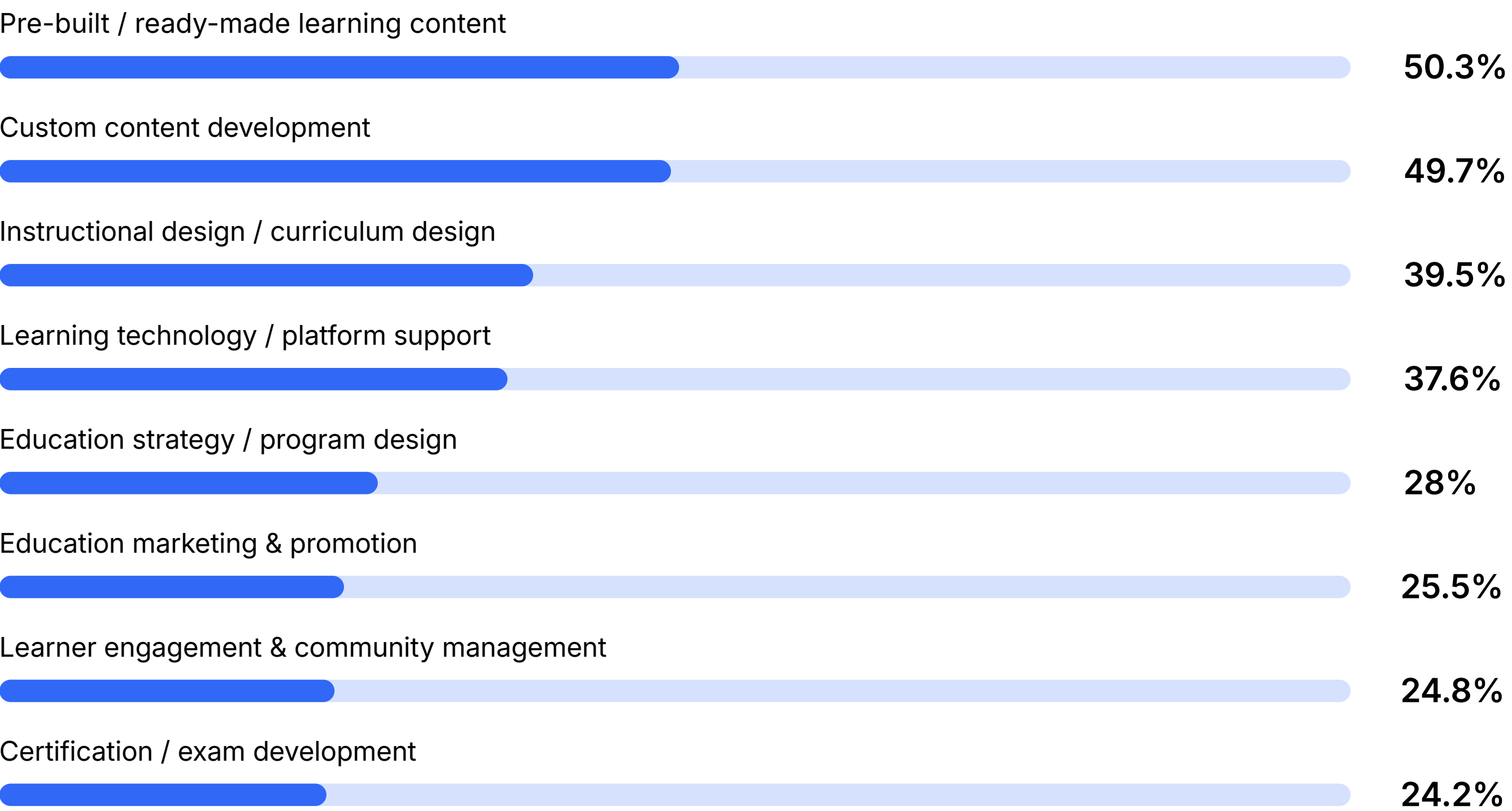
Use external vendor

16.9%

Do not use external vendor

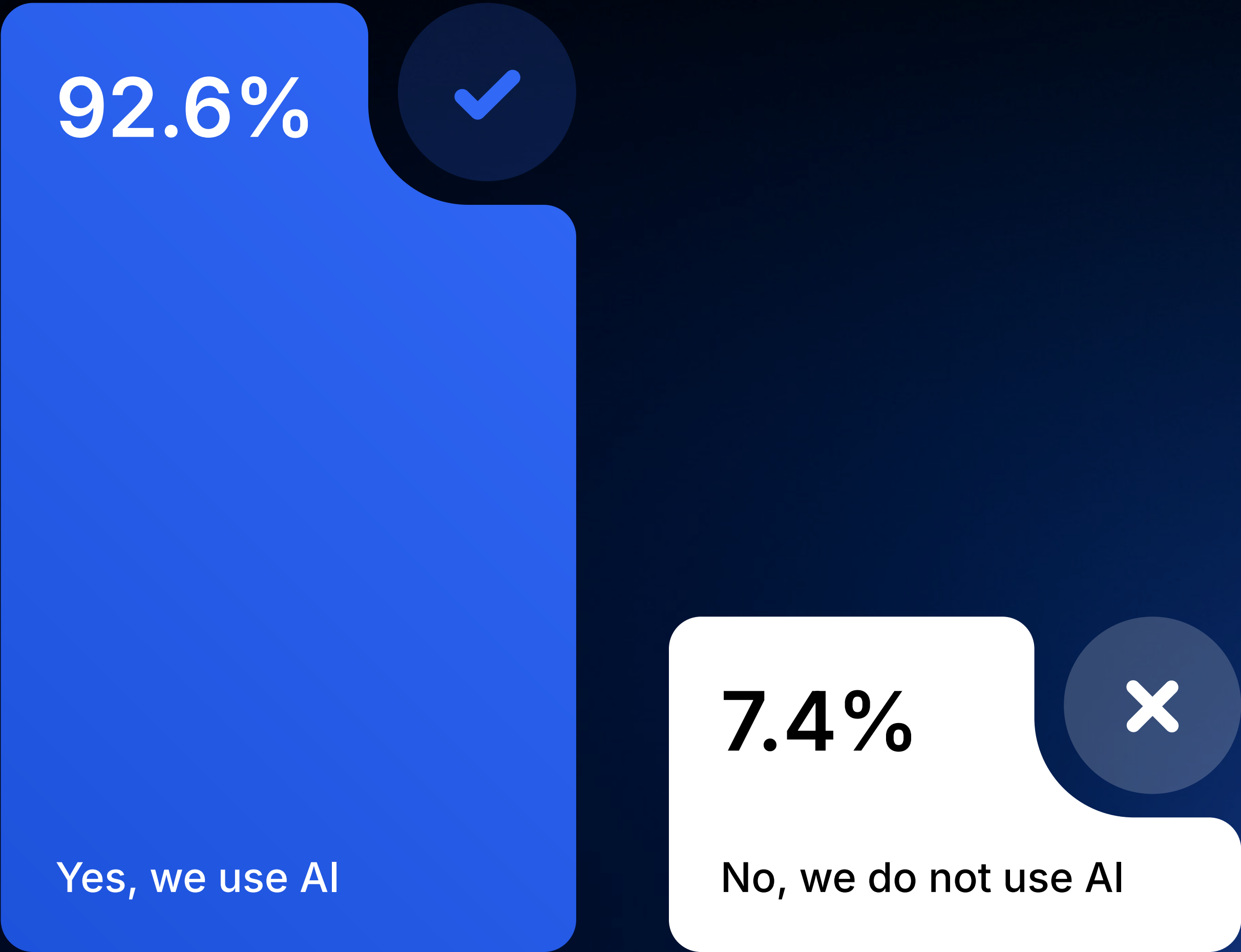
Content leads external vendor demand, followed by platform support.

Organizations most often rely on external vendors for content-related initiatives, with pre-built learning content (50.3%) and custom content development (49.7%) leading the list. Instructional design (39.5%) and learning technology/platform support (37.6%) also rank highly, reinforcing that while content remains the foundation of education programs, organizations increasingly rely on external expertise to support the platforms that deliver and scale those experiences.



AI is now widely adopted across education programs.

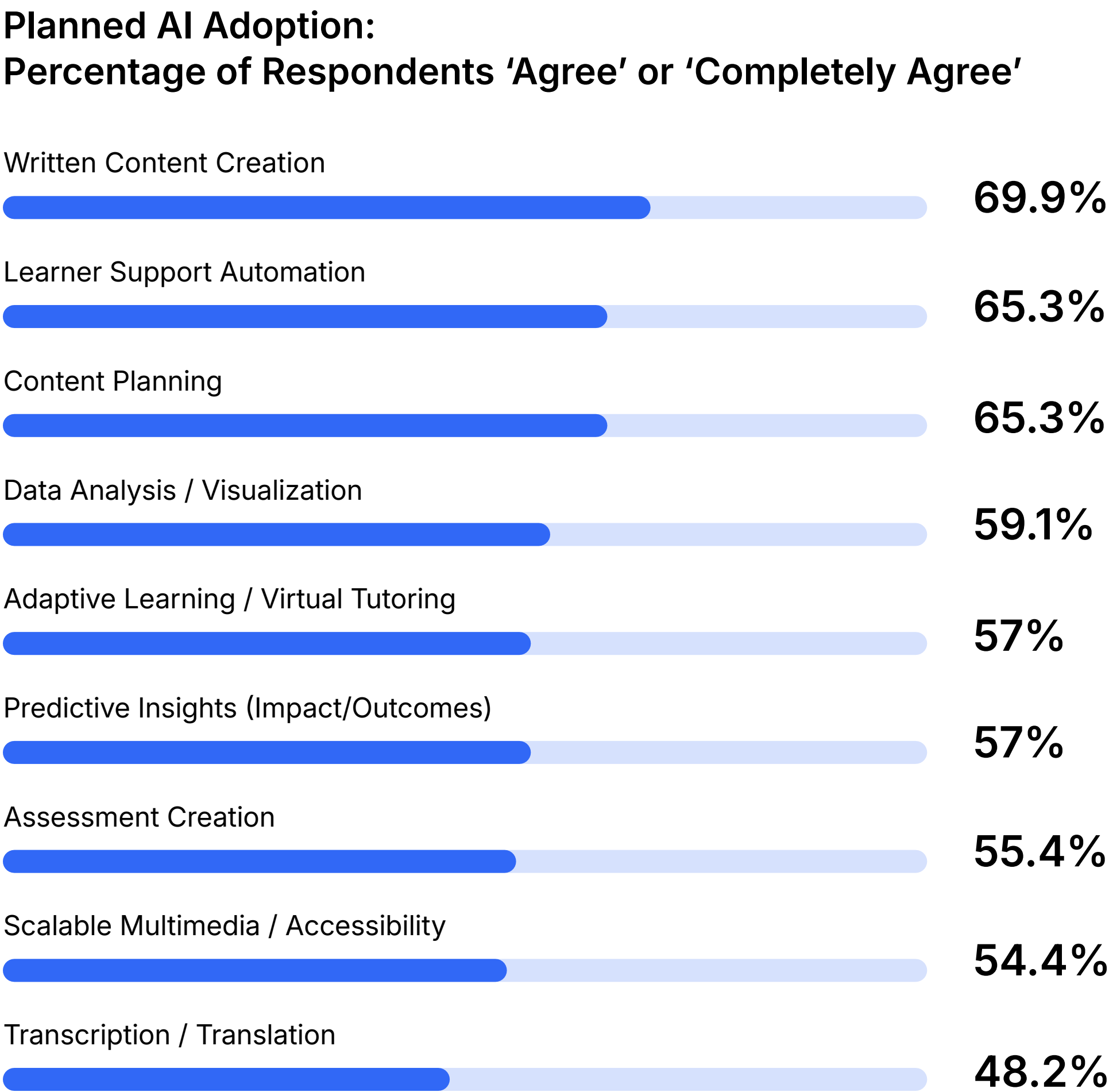
AI adoption in education programs is now widespread. 92.6% of respondents report using AI, signaling that the technology has moved rapidly from experimentation to practical implementation. This aligns closely with earlier predictions. [Forrester's 2024 research](#) projected that 99.6% of organizations expected to be using AI by 2026—suggesting that most education teams are already integrating AI into their programs.



Education teams prioritize AI for content creation and learner support.

Nearly 70% of respondents plan to leverage AI to accelerate written content creation, making it the single most common use case. Learner Support Automation (chatbots) and Content Planning are the second most popular uses, both selected by 65.3% of respondents. This shows a strong focus on both the strategic (planning) and operational (support) aspects of education delivery.

Smaller companies (100–499 employees) are focusing on immediate output (e.g., Written Content Creation, Assessment Creation, Scalable Multimedia), while midmarket/large companies (500-4,999 employees) have more focus on AI for content planning. The largest enterprises (20,000+ employees) have the most focus on AI for data analysis.



Marketing support varies significantly by education audience.

Marketing support for education programs varies significantly based on the audience served. External-only education teams report the strongest marketing support, with 37.5% having a dedicated marketer and nearly 72% having dedicated marketing resources overall. In contrast, internal-only teams are the most resource-constrained, with 40% reporting no marketing support. Teams serving both audiences fall in between, suggesting external education programs receive greater marketing investment.

Q: Which of the following represents your access to marketing for your education programs?

36.4%

We have dedicated resources from marketing.

33.5%

We have a dedicated marketer on our education team.

21.4%

We do our own marketing, though we don't have a dedicated marketer on the team.

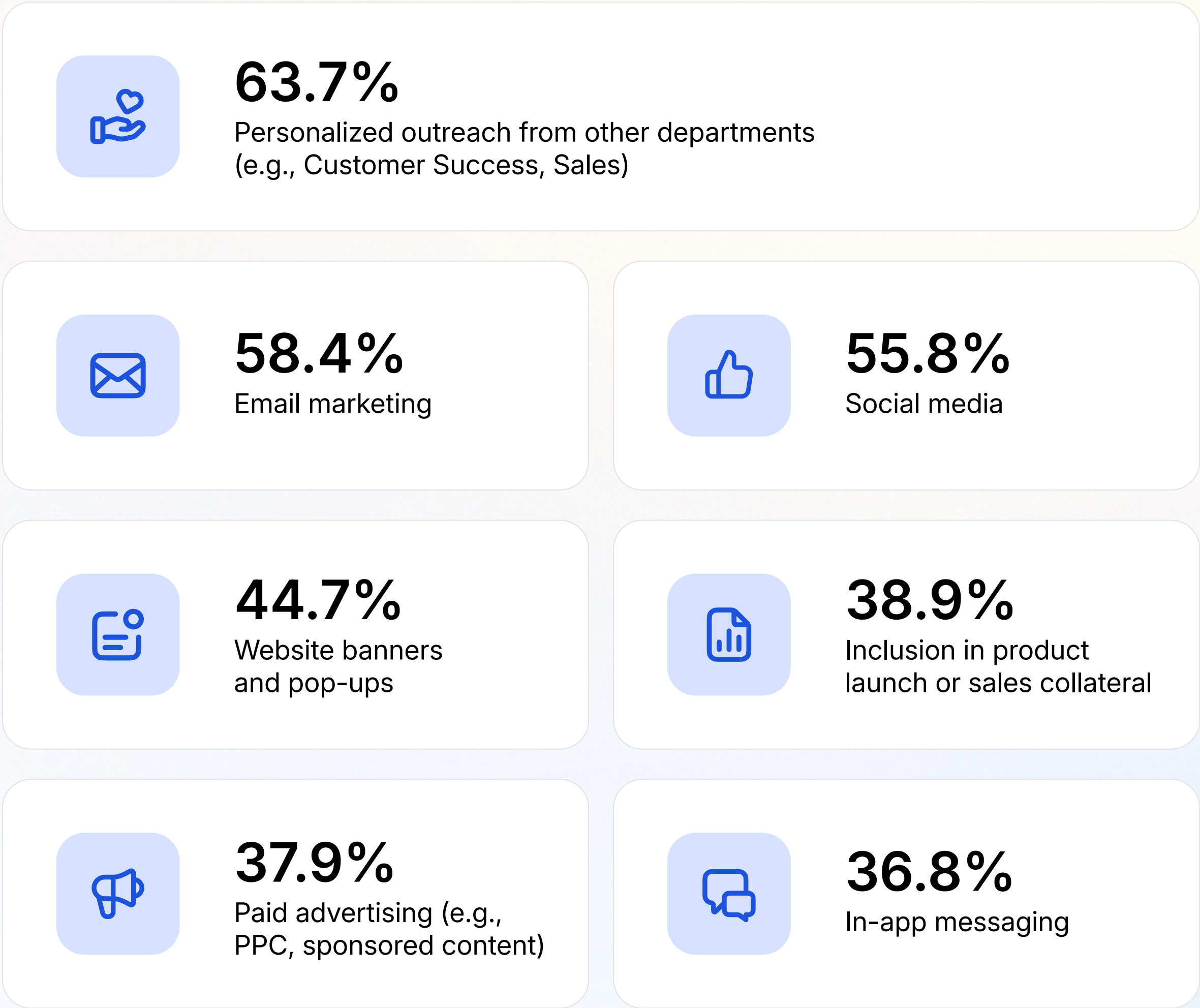
8.7%

We have no marketing resources for our education program.

Personalized outreach and email lead education promotion tactics.

Education teams rely on a consistent mix of channels to promote their programs. Personalized outreach from other departments (63.7%) and email marketing (58.4%) remain the most common tactics, followed by social media (55.8%). While teams use a variety of additional channels, usage patterns are largely consistent regardless of whether programs target internal or external audiences, suggesting most organizations apply similar promotion strategies across learner groups.

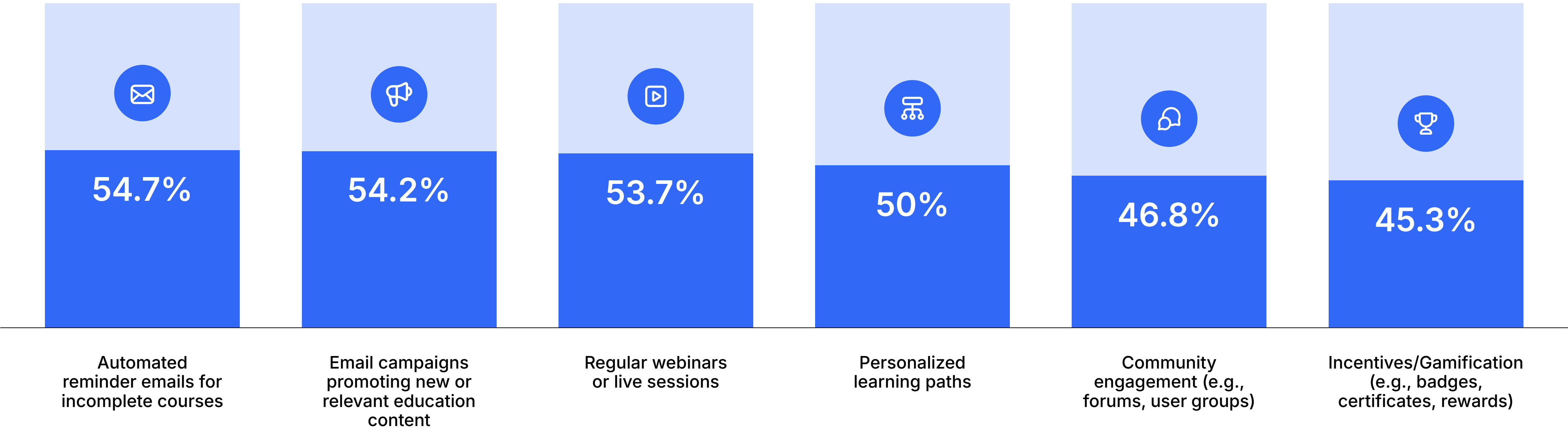
Q: What tactics do you use to promote your education programs? (Select all that apply.)



Email remains the primary driver of learner re-engagement.

Similar to the 2025 data, email remains the primary channel for re-engaging learners, followed by regular webinars or live sessions. Not surprisingly with the rise of AI, we see an increase in focus on personalized learning paths as a driver for re-engagement.

Q: How do you engage and re-engage learners over time? (Select all that apply.)





Audience type shapes re-engagement strategies.

Re-engagement strategies vary depending on the audience being educated. External education programs rely heavily on email campaigns (80.8%), making email the dominant tactic for driving continued engagement with customers and partners. Internal programs rely more on automated reminders (59.9%) and regular webinars or live sessions (56.6%). Community engagement is also more common externally, while personalized learning paths remain a consistent tactic across both audiences.

Most education leaders start measuring impact soon after a new initiative launches.

Measurement discipline continues to improve. 27% of respondents now measure impact immediately after launching an initiative (up from 25% in 2025), while 49% begin measuring within three months, a significant increase from 35% last year. Programs that measure earlier are also more likely to use specialized eLearning analytics tools, suggesting that faster measurement correlates with more mature analytics capabilities. Meanwhile, programs not consistently measuring dropped from 28% to just 5%.

Q: On average, how long after launching an education initiative do you start measuring its impact on business goals?



Education data lives in an expanding ecosystem around the LMS.

The LMS remains the foundation of most education programs, used by 41% of teams to measure impact. However, education data increasingly connects with other business systems. CRM (55.3%) and support platforms (51.6%) are among the most common sources, reflecting the growing role of education in customer outcomes. Together, these systems form an expanding analytics ecosystem around the LMS.

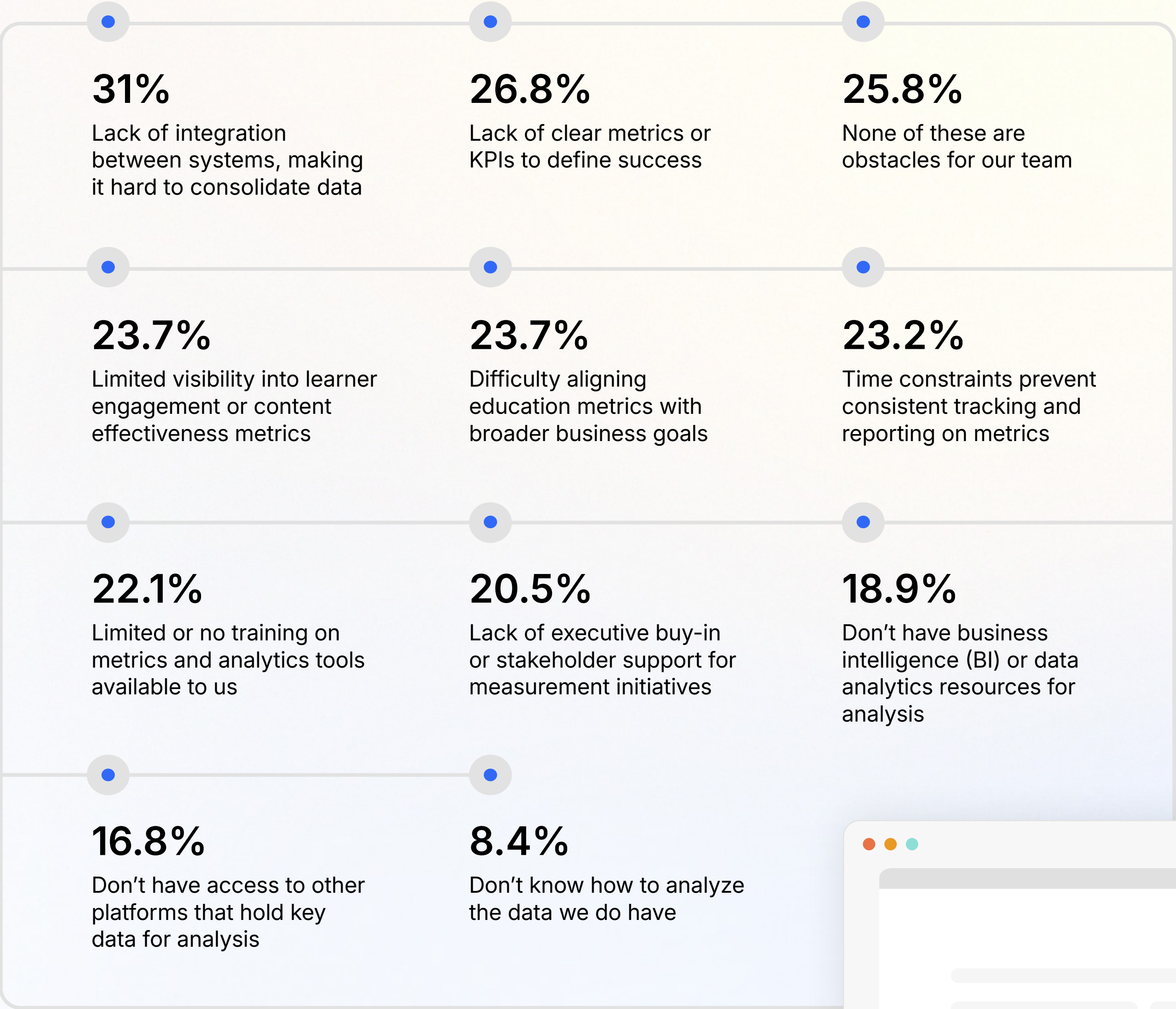
Q: Which analytics tool(s) is your education team using to measure impact? (Choose all that apply.)



Regardless of what's in the tech stack, most teams struggle with integration between systems to fully measure impact.

Integration between systems remains the top challenge for measuring education’s business impact, cited by 31% of respondents. However, the share reporting this issue is significantly lower than in 2025, suggesting progress in connecting learning data across systems. Notably, 26% report no major measurement obstacles, indicating that a growing number of teams are building the processes, metrics, and integrations needed to effectively demonstrate impact.

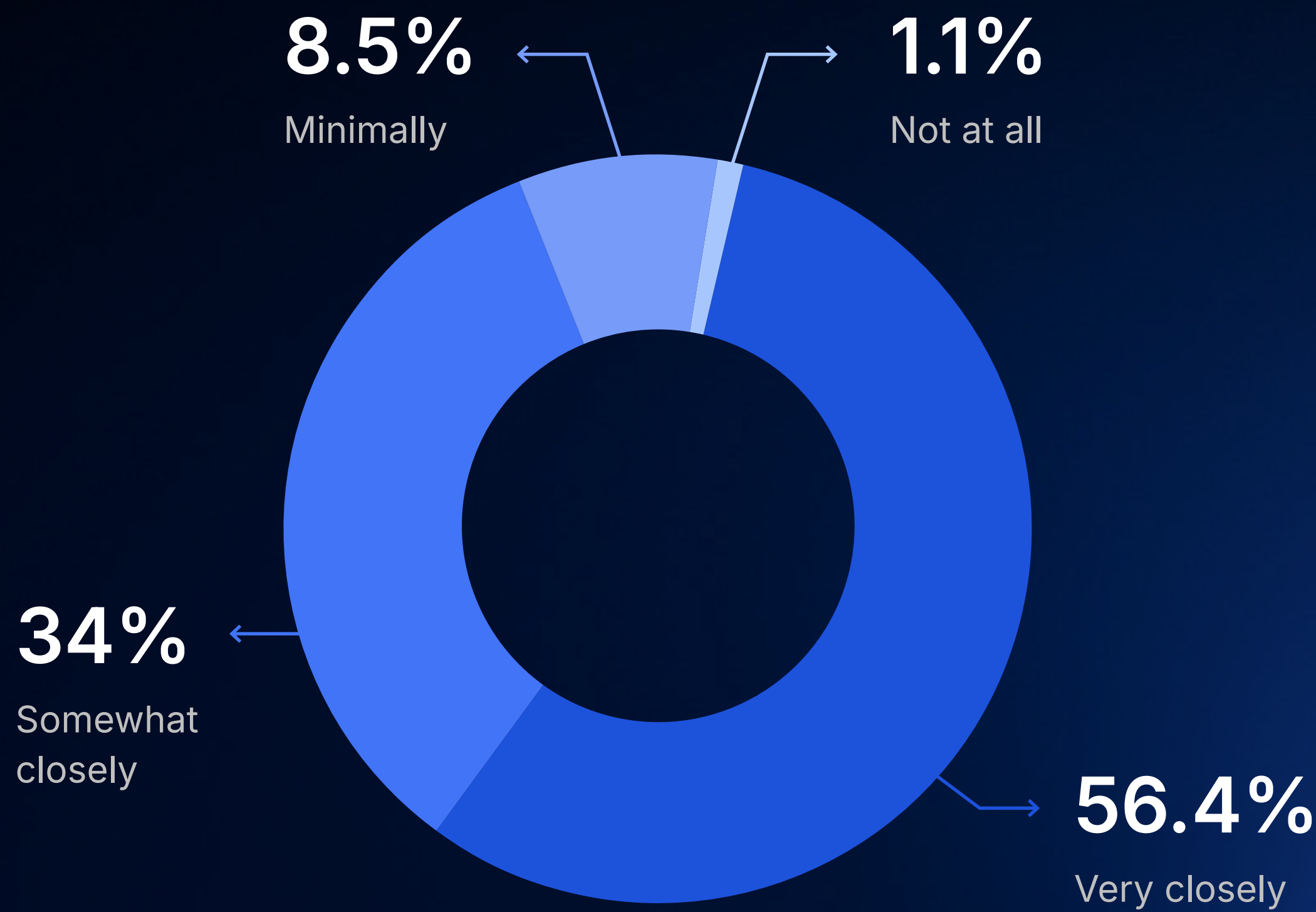
Q: Which of the following challenges prevent your team from effectively measuring and achieving business outcomes through education? (Choose all that apply.)



A majority of programs are tied to the broader success of the product(s) in the market.

Education programs are increasingly aligned with product success in the market. 68% of respondents say their programs are closely tied to product outcomes, and only 9.6% report minimal or no alignment, down sharply from 32% in 2025. This shift suggests education teams are becoming more integrated into go-to-market strategies, positioning education as a stronger driver of product adoption and market differentiation.

Q: How closely do you feel your team’s education programs are tied to the broader success of your product(s) in the market?



Education is integral to a company's go-to-market strategy—but there's room to grow.

Education continues to play a growing role in go-to-market strategy. The top two contributions remain customer onboarding/adoption (59.5%) and brand loyalty/retention (58.9%), consistent with 2025. However, all GTM-related roles increased year over year, including demand generation and upsell support. At the same time, far fewer teams report that education is not integrated into GTM, signaling stronger alignment between education and revenue-driving functions.

Q: What role does education play in your organization's go-to-market strategy? (Select all that apply.)



Key Recommendations

How do you make sure your education program is designed to deliver real business impact? Here are a few suggestions, based on the data:



Prioritize the audiences and lifecycle stages with the clearest business value.

Most programs already support implementation, adoption, and retention well. Look for opportunities to extend education into expansion and other high-value moments, rather than spreading resources too thin across every stage.



Strengthen the systems around your LMS.

The LMS remains foundational, but business impact is often proven through connected data from CRM, support, and analytics platforms. Improve the integrations and reporting workflows that help you connect learning activity to customer and business outcomes.



Design programs with measurement built in from the start.

Teams that measure impact immediately typically begin with a clear plan for what success looks like and how it will be measured. Define your success metrics before launch, ensure the necessary systems and integrations are in place, and establish reporting workflows so you can track outcomes as soon as the program goes live.



Use AI where it saves time fastest.

The most common AI use cases are written content creation, learner support, and planning. Start with high-volume, repeatable work (e.g., drafting content, summarizing material, or powering support workflows) before expanding into more advanced use cases.



Use outside expertise selectively.

Organizations most often use partners for content development, instructional design, and platform support. If internal bandwidth is limited, prioritize external help in the areas that are hardest to scale alone.

Recommended Resources

Need help taking action?
We've got you covered.



Not sure which metrics to measure or how to prove impact?

The Practical Guide to Metrics is about to become your best friend.



Curious how AI is shaping modern learning programs?

Explore our guide to Generative AI in Learning & Development.



Making the case to formalize or expand education?

Download our Business Case Template.



Looking for data to support the impact of customer education?

Download the 2024 Customer Education Benchmarks & Trends Report from Forrester.



Looking for practical ways to apply AI to your education strategy?

Download The Learning Leader's Guide to AI.



Research Methodology

For page 14, respondents selected from 12 possible objectives (select all that apply), which were then grouped into four overarching business outcomes—revenue, retention, performance, and cost reduction—to provide a clearer view of how education programs align with strategic goals

For a few questions, a respondent did not disclose an answer to the question and was removed from the analysis for this question.

Survey Period

Nov 2025 - Feb 2026

Verification

Respondents verified by name and email to ensure valid entries.

Response Handling

Undisclosed responses (skipped questions) were excluded from calculations. Percentages rounded to the nearest tenth of a percent.

Tools Used

Survicate & Centiment

For data collection.

Analysis conducted in Google Sheets, including descriptive statistics and cross-question relationship analysis.

Participants

Recruited through Customer Education Slack, Customer Education Management Association, email campaigns, LinkedIn, and Centiment.

Design

34 Questions

Primarily multiple-choice and "select all that apply."

Sample Size

190

Total respondents

Analysis

Basic percentage breakdown and deeper data relationship analysis through dashboards, exploring interdependencies between question responses.



About Intelium

Intelium provides a corporate education platform that includes all the tools an organization needs to create, deploy, manage, track, and continuously improve highly personalized, engaging educational experiences.

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A rising tide lifts all boats—and sharing this data on strategic priorities helps us all elevate the profession of customer education.

Our only request is that you cite and link to this report:

2026 Education-Led Growth™ Report →